virtual energy alliance. Indeed, China and Russia increasingly functioned like all-round strategic allies, with annual summits.

By 2018–19, then, the US and China were heading towards a Cold War, with India and Russia lining up with their preferred partners. Once again, Delhi and Beijing found themselves on opposite sides in global politics. In a dynamic that marked earlier periods, Delhi came to side with a bigger power principally because it feared China; and Beijing aligned with a partner not because it feared India, but rather to balance US power.

Conclusion

Situating India–China relations in a global history shows that India and China have never truly been on the same side except during the Second World War. Even then, Indians worked largely with the Kuomintang and not the communists in the fight against Japan. In terms of their partnerships, Delhi and Beijing had parallel and compatible interests in only two brief periods – in the early 1950s and in the decade after the Cold War, for a total of perhaps fifteen years in a seventy-year history. Crucially, despite these two brief ententes against the US, they have never been allies or true strategic partners against either the Soviets/Russians or the Americans. As allies or partners, India and China would have developed a history of give and take. Their leaderships, officials, and militaries would have got to know and trust each other more. Shared memories of collaboration could have helped tide over or even pre-empt conflict in other periods.

Instead, for much of the period from 1949 to the present, a supposedly non-aligned India, in varying degrees of intensity, partnered with the Soviets and the Americans in order to deter or balance China: in the 1960s, primarily with the Soviets and very briefly with the US; from 1971 to 1989, with the Soviets exclusively; and from about 2001 onward, with the US. On the other hand, China partnered both the Soviets and the US, but not because it needed to deter or balance India: it initially aligned with the